

Peter Jackson completes his **blockbuster** *Lord of the Rings* **trilogy**; Tarantino continues to show stylish invention with *Kill Bill: Volume 1*.

↑
2003

Guillermo del Toro **mixes fantasy with gritty realism** in his Spanish drama *Pan's Labyrinth*.

↑
2006

The Hurt Locker wins director **Kathryn Bigelow** an Oscar; Danny Boyle adds a touch of **Bollywood style** to *Slumdog Millionaire*.

↑
2008

Jackson's *The Hobbit: An Unexpected Journey* is the **first commercial feature** movie to be shot at a **high frame rate** of 48 frames per second.

↑
2012

2003

↓
Park Chan-wook's innovative and violent thriller *Oldboy* brings **South Korean cinema** to an international audience.

2007

↓
Paul Thomas Anderson tells a tale of **oil and greed** in his historical epic *There Will Be Blood*.

2011

↓
Turkish director Nuri Bilge Ceylan's *Once Upon a Time in Anatolia* charts the grim duties of a **homicide team**.

2013

↓
In *Gravity*, Alfonso Cuarón uses the latest computer technology to produce a visually stunning **3D space adventure**.

camcorders. Nothing would be the same again. In the short term, filmmakers now had cameras so small and light they could move through scenes with boundless agility. For some (among them Tarantino), the loss of film was an ongoing tragedy. For others, digital put filmmaking in the hands of people who could never have afforded to get their ideas on screen otherwise—and made the riches of movie history accessible to anyone with a memory stick.

The digital revolution not only transformed the way movies were shot, it also changed how they were seen, as noiseless digital projection replaced the time-honored whir of 35 mm.

Other barriers were also falling. *The Hurt Locker* was a movie that, in 2008, felt impossibly modern—

the jagged energy of its special effects ideal for a story about the Iraq War. More significant, perhaps, was that its director, Kathryn Bigelow, became the first woman to win an Oscar as Best Director.

Computer effects

For much of the course of this book, “special effects” were the preserve of a certain kind of movie: big-budget spectacles, the sons (and daughters) of *King Kong* and animator Ray Harryhausen. By now, movies of all kinds were being made in front of computers. German director Michael Haneke's hypnotically austere filmmaking could hardly have been further from the additive-packed summer blockbuster; yet *The White Ribbon*, his tale of strange goings-on among

the children of a German village in 1913, used digital technology to erase stray signs of modern life.

In the blockbuster *Gravity*, on the other hand, nothing was what it seemed; its outer space adventure had mostly been filmed with a lone Sandra Bullock locked for months into a “cage” in front of a green screen, “space” to be added later.

Yet Georges Méliès would surely have smiled at finding we were still thrilling ourselves with trips to the stars. While it was firmly earthbound, he would have admired *Boyhood* too: shot for a few days every year for 12 years to map one child's journey through life, it sounded like a gimmick. In fact, it reminded you, with enormous power, what it was to be human. What better emblem for the movies could there be? ■